

Auxiliary letters

An auxiliary letter is a type of silent letter that can change the pronunciation of a word. For example, if the letter *a* in *coat* is removed, this would spell another word, *cot*, which sounds different and has a different meaning from *coat*.

kite → Here, the silent *e* is an auxiliary letter because, if it is removed, the sound changes. It would also be confused with the existing word *kit*.

Letter	When it can be silent	Examples
a	after <i>o</i>	boat, coat, goat
b	after <i>m</i>	climb, comb, tomb
c	before <i>t</i>	indict
d	before <i>g</i>	badge, dodge, judge
e	at the end of a word	hope, kite, site
g	after <i>i</i> and before <i>n</i> after <i>i</i> and before <i>m</i>	benign, design, sign paradigm
h	after <i>c</i>	ache
i	only in one word	business
l	before <i>k</i> before <i>m</i>	folk, talk, walk calm, palm
s	after <i>i</i>	aisle, island
w	before <i>h</i>	who, whom, whose

Regional variations

One aspect that varies from one accent to the next is the silencing and sounding of particular letters. The English language includes a range of regional accents, each with its own peculiarities. Even so, two people raised in the same region might pronounce the same word differently.

better → Some speakers don't pronounce the final *r* in this word.

Letter	When it can be either silent or heard	Examples
h	before <i>e</i> after <i>w</i>	herb which, whip, whiskey
r	after a vowel	born, car, star
t	before or after another consonant	often, fasten, tsunami

About **60 percent** of English words contain a **silent letter**.

👍

- Some words that contain silent letters stem from **other languages**. The words *knife*, *knock* and *know*, which all have a **silent k**, are **Old Norse** words. The words *bright*, *daughter* and *night*, which all contain the **silent gh**, are **Anglo-Saxon** words.